

Arthritis Pain Management — A Kind, Practical Guide

Manage arthritis pain with a whole-person approach. Covers movement, heat and cold, medication, mindfulness, sleep, complementary therapies, and emotional support.

By **Living With Arthritis Editorial Team** · Pending clinical review ·
2026-06-16 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk

Pending clinical review. Last updated: June 2026.

Pain is the thing people most fear about arthritis. It can steal your sleep, sap your energy, and shrink your world. But pain is not simply something you must endure. It can be understood, managed, and — for many people — significantly reduced. This guide takes a whole-person approach. Pain is not just about joints. It is affected by how you move, eat, sleep, think, and feel. The more tools you have, the more control you gain.

Understanding Arthritis Pain

Arthritis pain is not a simple signal from a damaged joint to your brain. It is shaped by many factors: physical damage (cartilage loss, inflammation, joint changes), muscle tension (when joints hurt, surrounding muscles tighten protectively — causing more pain), sensitisation (over time the nervous system can become "tuned up" making pain feel worse than the physical damage alone would suggest), emotions and stress (anxiety, low mood, and stress lower pain tolerance and amplify pain), and fatigue and poor sleep (pain and sleep are locked in a miserable dance — pain disrupts sleep, and poor sleep makes pain worse). Managing pain effectively requires addressing more than just the joint.

Movement and Exercise for Pain Relief



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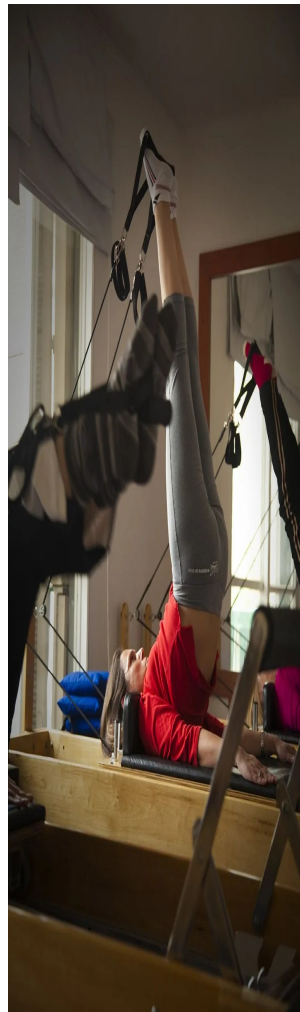
It is the oldest paradox in arthritis: movement hurts, but not moving hurts more. Every NICE guideline on arthritis places exercise at the centre of pain management. Why it works: strengthening muscles reduces load on joints; movement stimulates synovial fluid release lubricating joints; exercise triggers endorphins — your body's natural painkillers; regular movement "calms down" a sensitised nervous system over time. What kind? Walking (start with 5–10 minutes), swimming or pool-based exercise, cycling, yoga or tai chi, physio-prescribed strength exercises. The key is **pacing**. A little every day beats a lot once a week.

Heat and Cold Therapy

Simple, cheap, and genuinely effective. **Heat therapy** is best for stiff, achy chronic pain (especially OA-related) — it relaxes muscles, improves blood flow, and eases stiffness. Try a warm bath or shower, a microwavable wheat bag, an electric heat pad (low setting, never

sleep with it on), or warm water exercises. **Cold therapy** is best for hot, swollen, inflamed joints (common in RA, gout, or acute OA flares) — it numbs the area and reduces swelling. Try a bag of frozen peas wrapped in a tea towel (15 minutes max), a gel ice pack (never directly on skin), or a bowl of cool water for hands or feet. Some people find alternating heat and cold helpful.

Pain Medications — What Works



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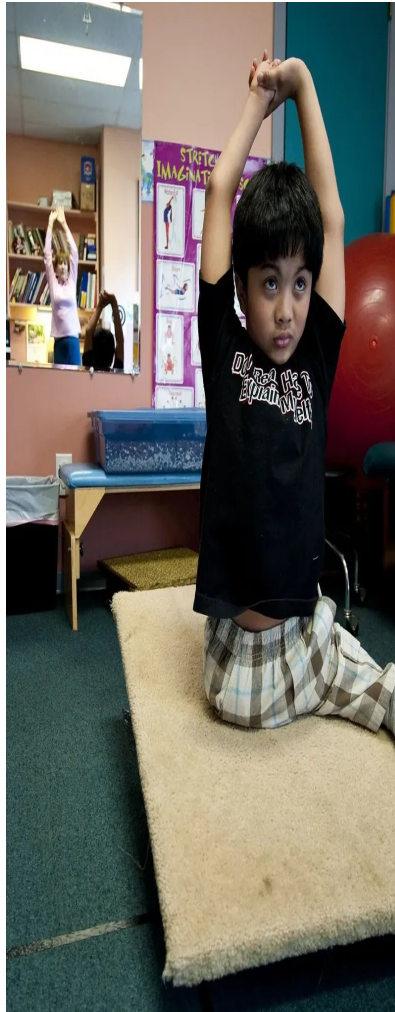
Medication is one tool among many. Paracetamol for mild-to-moderate pain (over the counter). NSAIDs (ibuprofen, naproxen) for pain plus inflammation (over the counter or prescription). Topical gels for localised joint pain (over the counter). Opioids (codeine, tramadol) for severe short-term pain (prescription only). DMARDs/biologics for underlying inflammation in RA (prescription, specialist). Steroid injections for flare-ups in a single joint (GP or rheumatologist).

Always take medication at the dose prescribed and speak to your GP before making changes.

Mindfulness and Relaxation Techniques

It might sound "soft" compared to medication or surgery — but mindfulness and relaxation have solid evidence for reducing chronic pain. A 2019 review in the *British Journal of Pain* found mindfulness-based interventions reduced pain intensity and improved quality of life. Why it helps: reduces muscle tension, lowers stress hormones that amplify pain, changes your relationship with pain — making it feel less overwhelming. Simple techniques: box breathing (in for 4, hold for 4, out for 4, hold for 4 — repeat 5 times), body scan (lie down and mentally scan from toes to head noticing and releasing tension), guided relaxation apps (NHS-recommended like Headspace and Calm offer free sessions), progressive muscle relaxation (tense each muscle group for 5 seconds then release — work from feet to face).

Sleep and Pain — Breaking the Cycle



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Pain makes sleep hard. Poor sleep makes pain worse. Breaking this cycle is one of the most impactful things you can do. Stick to a schedule — same bedtime and wake time every day. Create a wind-down ritual: a warm bath, a book (not a screen), gentle stretches, a heat pack. Manage your sleep environment: a supportive mattress, a pillow between your knees for hip or knee pain, cool room temperature. Avoid caffeine after 2pm and alcohol close to bedtime. If you wake in pain, have a plan — a wheat bag by the bed, medication within reach, a guided breathing exercise queued on your phone. If sleep problems persist, speak to your GP.

Complementary Approaches

Some approaches with reasonable evidence: **acupuncture** (NICE does not recommend it for OA on the NHS, but some people report meaningful relief — private sessions cost £40–£80), **massage therapy** (may ease muscle tension around painful joints), **TENS** (a small device delivering mild electrical pulses — NICE does not recommend for OA but some find it helpful,

units cost £20–£50), **capsaicin cream** (from chilli peppers, applied to skin over a joint — takes 1–2 weeks of regular use to work).

Creating Your Pain Management Toolkit

Daily tools: gentle movement, heat pack during your morning coffee, anti-inflammatory food choices, mindfulness practice. **Bad-day tools:** pain medication as prescribed, ice or heat as needed, pacing — do one important thing then rest, distraction — a film, a friend, a book. **Emergency tools (severe flare):** GP or rheumatologist contact details, flare plan (medications, rest strategy), support network — someone to help with shopping, children, or pets.

When Pain Affects Your Mood — Getting Support

Living with persistent pain changes how you feel. It is not a sign of weakness to struggle. Anxiety and depression are more common in people with arthritis than in the general population. The NHS takes this seriously. Talk to your GP — they can refer you to NHS talking therapies (IAPT). These are free and effective. Join a support group — Arthritis Action and Arthritis UK run groups across the UK, in person and online. Be honest with loved ones — hiding how you feel makes it harder for people to support you. Pain is not your fault. And you do not have to manage it alone.

Q&A

Question: What is the key thing to know about arthritis pain management — a kind, practical guide?

Short answer: Arthritis pain is influenced by physical factors, muscle tension, nervous system sensitisation, emotions, and sleep. Effective management takes a whole-person approach: exercise, sensible medication use, heat and cold therapy, and mindfulness. Prioritising sleep, setting realistic daily goals, and having a plan for flare-ups reduces pain and improves well-being. If pain affects your mood, speak to your GP.

Question: When should I seek professional advice?

Short answer: If symptoms persist or worsen, pain is severe and unresponsive to usual relief, or you develop new symptoms, contact your GP, physiotherapist or rheumatology team promptly.

Question: Where can I get free arthritis support in the UK?

Short answer: Arthritis UK: 0800 5200 520. NRAS: 0800 298 7650. Free tools and guides at livingwitharthritis.org.uk.

General information only — not medical advice. Consult your GP or specialist before changing medication or starting a new programme. Emergency: 999. NHS advice: 111. Living With Arthritis · livingwitharthritis.org.uk